

The Glorious Secret Tantra of the Vajra Ḍākinī, the King of Tantras

Śrī Vajraḍākinī Guhyatantrarāja · Toh 399 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་རྩོམ་མཁའ་འགྲོ་སངས་བཟའ་རྒྱ་ཀྱི་ཐུག་པོ།

Toh 399 in the Kangyur is a tantric scripture known in English as The Glorious Secret Tantra of the Vajra Ḍākinī, King of Tantras, corresponding to the Sanskrit Śrī Vajraḍākinī Guhyatantrarāja and the Tibetan Dpal rdo rje mkha' 'gro gsang ba'i rgyud kyi rgyal po. It belongs to the class of Anuttarayoga or higher yoga tantras and centers on teachings associated with the Heruka cycle, addressing esoteric subjects such as empowerment, the nature of samayas and their confession, and the non-dual relationship between sentient beings and buddhas. The text is cast as a dialogue in which a questioner poses profound doctrinal questions and the Blessed One responds by expounding the illusory yet certain nature of empowerment and the dissolution of conceptual duality into primordial wisdom. It was translated into Tibetan by the monk Śākyayeśe and is preserved among the tantric scriptures of the Kangyur.

Translated by the monk Śākyayeśe.

In the Indian language: Śrī Vajraḍākinī Guhyatantrarāja.

In the Tibetan language: The Glorious Secret Tantra of the Vajra Ḍākinī, the King of Tantras.

Homage to the Glorious Heruka.

Kyé ho! O Protector of manifest perfection, kyé!

Are there truly supreme empowerments?

Is there truly no difference between principal and retinue?

Is there truly no distinction between sentient beings and buddhas?

What are the greater and lesser samayas (sacred pledges)?

Is there a means to confess their breakage?

The Blessed One declared:

In order to halt conceptual thought and subject-object duality, and to pour in self-awareness as primordial wisdom, the empowerments exist as mere illusion. In the nature of the yogin's mind, empowerment is indeed certain. With respect to the complete wholesomeness of body and speech, the defilements of the mind are therefore said to be like earth, water, fire, wind, and space — to be washed, scattered, burned, and cleared away, opening the

ground of knowing. The first, second, and third empowerments: without progressing through them in order, one does not obtain empowerment. For those who are well-established in the generation stage and who desire the completion stage, the fully awakened buddhas have taught this method to be like the successive rungs of a ladder. It comprises the supreme individual and the beginner, the stages of realization, and the branches of realization. Through this, one is liberated from the realms of lower existence, by means of the connection between empowerment and oral instruction.

Then the fourth, the empowerment of the vajra master's word: it has no preliminary and no non-preliminary. This is the king of empowerments; the master is the king of mind. This is the fourth empowerment of self-awareness. Through it, all are liberated. To this one should always pay homage and the like.

As for images fully formed from stone, wood, clay, and the like, and images fully formed on cloth, pigment, and the like: one invokes the blessing, draws down the primordial wisdom, declares it to be the deity, and offers worship accordingly. But since these are fabricated and such, while the aggregates and so forth are primordially buddha — why then would one not worship these?

Then there are further distinctions: those of confusion and the basis of confusion, the fabricated and the nearly fabricated, and those resembling such things — through the four empowerments, these do not lead to liberation. Through wrong craving, one is bound in existence; through the wheel of delusion, one revolves in saṃsāra. Therefore, even those who desire accomplishment (siddhi, Skt. siddhi) must abandon the māras of god-sons and always rely on a holy guru. Through trust, family, and certainty, one comes to understand: scripture is a valid authority — abandon the inferior and attain the superior; take what is valid as oral instruction. One should follow in accordance with one's aspiration, abide in the pride of greatness, and not take up the vessel and contents mixed with the views and conduct of the world.

Then, as to the distinctions between principal and retinue: the distinction of place is the center; the distinction of ornament is ash; the distinction of family is the sixth family. Then again, as to the distinctions of principal and retinue: by the distinctions of hands, feet, and so forth, the principal is superior to the retinue. As an example: just as without the Perfection of Wisdom among the six perfections, the remaining five cannot bear the name of perfection — so too, whoever dwells at the center of the maṇḍala, that itself is the maṇḍala. If

one does not dwell at the center, the retinue do not become the maṇḍala. It is just like a village or city without a king.

Likewise, as to the distinctions of samaya: if the root samaya is broken, the branch samayas are the same. If the samaya of mind is broken, the samayas of body and speech are the same. If the samaya of not taking life is broken, those of false speech and taking what is not given are the same, as is the samaya of desire. If the samaya of view is broken, the samaya of conduct is the same. Pretending virtue while being non-virtuous, even in aspiration alone — the breaking of samaya is the same as that.

Just as the seven precious treasures, separated from a wheel-turning king, cannot obtain the name "wheel-turning," so all of this is to be understood from the mouth of the guru.

Then again, buddhas and sentient beings: though there is not even the slightest difference between them, it is through self-awareness and other-awareness, through conditions, through the mind's being workable or unworkable, through the extent of karma, through being reversed or unreversed, through being capable or incapable of effective action, and through being complete or incomplete that buddhas and sentient beings appear as two. Yet they are not to be conceived as truly distinct — like the water element, gold, and space, their nature is held to be pure from the very beginning. When one's own mind is recognized by oneself, sentient beings are buddhas from the very beginning.

Vajravārāhī then asked: "You have spoken to me of the distinctions of samaya — those of taking life and so forth. Now the Blessed One declared:

Even if one's own body, speech, and mind are stirred, if the perception of killing does not arise, the breach of the samaya of taking life is certainly minor. The perception of harm experienced by another is taught to be a middling breach. Greater than that is assuredly the major breach.

Even if what is taken without it being given is small, if a great affliction arises in the other, that itself is assuredly a middling breach. If much is taken but the affliction is small, it is middling. If the affliction is great in a major taking, that is assuredly major alone.

Pretending virtue is a great downfall. Unknowing, heedlessness, forgetfulness, and the like are taught to be middling.

Furthermore, the measure of arising — whether great, middling, or minor — for other breaches of samaya is to be known from the causes and conditions of oneself, of another, or of both together. When one is seized by the very nature of a downfall, the outer and inner vajra-master erects the great maṇḍala in one's presence and one confesses in accordance with the proper procedure. The maṇḍala of the guru — upper and lower, in their distinctions of samaya — is to be understood.

Furthermore, as a specific form of confession: in order to burn away misdeeds through fire offering (homa), the great inner fire offering is to be undertaken. The profound fire is the fire of continuous, uninterrupted practice. The fire of the continuity of method — seven years or one year — is the great external fire of continuous practice. Seven months or three months is taught as middling. Seven days and the like as the fire of minor continuous practice. The elaborate and so forth are the same.

The cāṇḍālī (tumo), which has abided from the very beginning in its inherent nature, is the wisdom fire by nature — this is the fire of great continuous practice, for it abides without beginning or end. The fuel of broken samaya and the like is the fuel of the wisdom fire. When burned by one who holds the oral instructions, the wood of breakage and the like is assuredly consumed. The filling-ladle and so forth are likewise the same; the elaborate and so forth are similar to that.

Receive this tantra through entrustment and hold it well. May all rejoice and be glad.

The glorious Vajraḍākinī, the Secret Tantra, King of Tantras, is complete.

Translated by the Indian paṇḍita Gayādhara and the translator, the monk Śākyayeśes.

Translator's Notes

- The phrase rendered as "the pride of greatness" reflects a tantric technical usage in which divine pride, the meditative identification with the deity's exalted nature, is enjoined rather than ordinary arrogance; context makes this the intended sense.

The "sixth family" refers to a tantric classification system in which deities are organized into families, the sixth being associated with Vajrasattva or a specific heruka lineage depending on the system; this is a technical term left partly opaque by the text itself.

The list "washed, scattered, burned, and cleared away, opening the ground of knowing" corresponds to the five elements earth, water, fire, wind, and space as the five modes of purification in this empowerment context; the Tibetan syntax is compressed and the rendering

represents the most coherent reading.

- The phrase rendered "other-awareness" translates ལྟོས་ཤིང་ལྟོས་པ་, a rare compound; in context it contrasts with ལྟོས་པ་ (self-awareness) and refers to the awareness of what is other, i.e., the cognizing of external objects. The pair distinguishes between the reflexive, self-illuminating quality of buddha-mind and the outward-directed cognition characteristic of ordinary sentient being mind.

The term ལྟོས་པ་ལྟོས་པ་ (literally "setting aside the continuity" or "interruption of the stream") is rendered "continuous practice" in context with ལྟོས་ (fire), where the compound means a sustained or uninterrupted fire offering; the gradation of seven years, one year, seven months, three months, and seven days reflects a standard graduated system of homa practice for purification.

The closing colophon names the translator as Śākyayeśes, the well-known Tibetan monk-translator who worked with the Indian paṇḍita Gayādhara; this confirms the text belongs to the early transmission period of the Vajraḍākinī Tantra cycle.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.